



Preparing for a wider Union

Strasbourg, 6 October 2026

The European Commission has adopted a package on pre-enlargement policy reviews, setting out the policy orientations and actions needed to prepare the Union for future enlargements.

As announced by President **von der Leyen** in her [2023 State of the Union address](#) and as mandated by the European Council, the measures proposed today prepare the Union's governance, policies and budget for enlargement, while strengthening the protection of the Union's values and the rule of law.

European Commission President Ursula **von der Leyen** said: *"Europe's future depends on the choices we make today. Enlargement of our Union is a geopolitical imperative. Today, we are laying the groundwork to ensure that a larger Union is also a stronger one: more resilient, more effective, and firmly anchored in the values and rules that define us. As enlargement countries advance on their path of reform, the EU must be ready to welcome them. This means preparing our institutions, adapting our policies for new realities, and ensuring our budget reflects our shared ambitions."*

In today's package the Commission provides an in-depth assessment of our policies in light of upcoming enlargements. It sets out how the existing Treaty framework and future accession treaties can be used to prepare the Union for a larger membership.

It also proposes a set of safeguards for future accession treaties, including stronger sectoral safeguards and a new institutional safeguard clause, to ensure that commitments undertaken during accession negotiations continue to be fulfilled steadily after accession.

The package also reinforces the gradual integration process by making it more coherent, more structured and predictable. This enhanced process will further support candidate countries prepare for membership through earlier participation in selected Union policies, provided conditions are met. This can build administrative capacity, strengthen preparedness for accession and deliver tangible benefits for citizens and businesses both in the EU and in enlargement countries before membership. Participation would remain merit-based, conditional and reversible, and depend on policy readiness and strategic alignment.

Today's package will feed into the strategic discussion among Member States on enlargement and reforms, including at the European Council in October. It will guide the work with the European Parliament and the Council on institutional and operational adjustments required for future accessions.

Adapting policies for a wider Union

The policy reviews presented today show that the Union can accommodate a larger membership within the existing Treaty framework and accession treaties. Across policy areas, administrative capacity and implementation are the most recurrent requirements, both within the EU and in the enlargement countries. Skills, regulatory and supervisory capacity, interoperable systems and cooperation between administrations must and will be strengthened before accession.

In terms of budgetary arrangements, the policy reviews underline that the Union budget can accommodate new Member States while continuing to finance the Union's existing priorities. Under the next [Multiannual Financial Framework proposal for 2028-2034](#), candidates would be funded under Global Europe before accession; at accession, this would transition into the new Member State's National and Regional Partnership Plans, with additional funding for cohesion, agriculture, Home Affairs and Interreg. For Ukraine, given the scale, structure and very high productivity of its agricultural sector, targeted arrangements should significantly limit financial support and market access for sensitive agricultural products, while helping Ukraine regain access to its traditional third-country export markets.

Strengthening governance for a larger Union

In the current geopolitical environment, the EU must adapt its governance to make decision-making swifter and more effective. By making the most of the possibilities under the Treaties, the Union can strengthen its capacity to act, prepare for future members and become better equipped for the future.

To this end, the Commission will continue to advocate the use of passerelle clauses to move from unanimity to qualified majority voting in key areas such as sanctions, tax fraud and fiscal measures in energy policy. In addition, the Commission will review pending proposals to identify where enhanced cooperation could help overcome a persistent blockage. In the area of enlargement, the Commission is suggesting to use of qualified majority voting for the opening of the negotiating clusters and other intermediary decisions in accession negotiations, making the process more dynamic.

The Commission also proposes to explore with the European Parliament and the Council a more effective handling of Article 7 procedures, including possible timeframes. The annual [Enlargement](#) and [Rule of Law](#) Reports will continue to serve as the main monitoring tools, with the latter extended to other candidate countries as and when they are ready.

Gradually integrating candidate countries into the EU

Closer integration should bring tangible benefits to citizens and businesses in both the EU and candidate countries. The Commission will map existing gradual integration instruments and identify opportunities to deepen integration in strategic sectors such as energy, transport, digital and defence. It will complement and reinforce the accession process, build administrative capacity and mutual trust, while remaining conditional and reversible. The Commission will launch annual dialogues with enlargement partners to track progress, identify opportunities, and address gaps in gradual integration.

Sectoral and institutional safeguards

As announced in the [2025 Communication on EU enlargement policy](#), future accession treaties should include stronger safeguards against serious backsliding on commitments undertaken during the accession negotiations. Today, the Commission is proposing a common framework for these safeguards. Future accession treaties would strengthen the existing sectoral safeguards and introduce a new institutional safeguard. In particular, the period during which safeguards can be activated in areas such as the economy, the internal market, and justice and home affairs, would be significantly extended after accession. A dedicated institutional safeguard would address serious breaches of Article 2 TEU values and the principle of sincere cooperation. In the most serious cases, measures could include the suspension of Council voting rights. Transitional arrangements could also be used where needed, including for the free movement of workers and services, agriculture, sensitive products, funding and participation in common systems. For a limited period, a new Member State could also commit not to block future enlargements because of bilateral disputes.

Next steps

The Commission invites the European Council and the European Parliament to advance discussions and institutional preparations and policy measures.

As part of the 2026 Enlargement package, the Commission will present indicative roadmaps for Montenegro, Albania, Moldova and Ukraine, provided they maintain reform momentum. It will also present a coherent approach for the gradual integration, including a mapping of the strategic areas.

The Commission will also work with Member States and candidate countries to align accession negotiations with the Union's internal preparations.

Background

In her 2023 State of the Union address, President **von der Leyen** called on the Union to match the determination of enlargement countries and announced pre-enlargement policy reviews. The [Granada Declaration](#) that same year set out the parallel responsibilities of enlargement countries to advance their reforms and of the Union to undertake the necessary internal preparations. The Commission's [March 2024 Communication on the pre-enlargement policy reviews](#) outlined a work programme covering four areas: values, policies, the budget and governance. In June 2024, the European Council [adopted](#) a roadmap for future work on internal reforms and invited the Commission to present in-

depth policy reviews with operational elements in those four areas.

In the [Political Guidelines for 2024–2029](#), the Commission committed to put forward proposals to strengthen the Union's capacity to act. In parallel, the European Parliament set out its position through its [2023 proposals for Treaty reform](#) and its [2025 report and resolution on the institutional consequences of enlargement negotiations](#).

For more information

[Questions and answers](#)

[Communication 'Preparing for a wider Union'](#)

[Staff Working Document on pre-enlargement policy reviews](#)

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Quote(s):

"Europe's future depends on the choices we make today. Enlargement of our Union is a geopolitical imperative. Today, we are laying the groundwork to ensure that a larger Union is also a stronger one: more resilient, more effective, and firmly anchored in the values and rules that define us. As enlargement countries advance on their path of reform, the EU must be ready to welcome them. This means preparing our institutions, adapting our policies for new realities, and ensuring our budget reflects our shared ambitions."

Ursula von der Leyen, President of the European Commission

"Our assessment shows that the EU can accommodate a larger membership. But there are areas where we see challenges we need to address. One is the rule of law and sincere cooperation, where we are proposing stronger possibilities to prevent backsliding, including reducing funding or restricting voting rights. Second, we propose to consider targeted arrangements for the integration of Ukraine's agricultural sector. And we are proposing ways to make our institutions leaner and able to take decisions faster. These changes need to make sure that a larger European Union is also a stronger Union, able to shape its own future."

Marta Kos, Commissioner for Enlargement

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[Read-out of the weekly meeting of the von der Leyen Commission by Marta Kos, European Commissioner, on the pre-enlargement policy reviews](#)